Unit 4. How to encounter a Bible passage (Tools)

Overview

This unit builds on Unit 3 and helps you learn how to discover the original message of a passage of Scripture for yourself. Later in the module we will learn how to preach or teach that message today.

'Scripture sculpture' is one name for the whole process and you will learn the meaning of that term. The first steps, taught in this unit, help you to understand a passage of the Bible. The last steps, taught in Unit 13, help you to teach it.

The first four steps are applied to 2 Tim 1:6-7 so that you can see how they work in practice. Those steps are essential to the BUILD curriculum and will be used throughout as we constantly move from understanding texts to teaching those texts.

Outline

- Introducing 'Scripture sculpture'
- Four steps for encountering a passage of the Bible
- The four steps applied to 2 Tim 1:6-7
- Pulling it all together
- Conclusion: Responding to the message of 2 Timothy 1:6-7

Outcomes

By the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Explain how Unit 3 relates to Unit 4
2. List the first steps of the Scripture Sculpture process
3. Begin to use the four steps for encountering a Bible passage
4. Respond to God's word in 2 Timothy 1:6-7

4.1 INTRODUCING 'SCRIPTURE SCULPTURE'

Units 2 and 3 taught some principles for understanding the Bible today and applied them to 1 and 2 Timothy. A main principle is this:

"We must **discover** what God has said in the past before we can **declare** it today."

This unit focuses on discovering what God has said in the past.

In order to discover what God has said in the past we will learn the first steps in a process called 'Scripture Sculpture'. Scripture Sculpture is a process with a series of steps that take us from the Scriptures to a sermon. In other words, from reading a passage to preaching a passage.

This unit teaches the first steps under the title "How to encounter a Bible passage".

Unit 13 is called "How to preach a Bible passage" and completes the process.

The steps are taken from Ramesh Richard's 'Scripture Sculpture' method and have been adapted with his personal permission. The process is simple, natural and was developed in India.

- What do you understand by the word 'sculpture'?

If you are unfamiliar with the word, sculpture is an art and a craft. It might mean carving a beautiful object out of wood or making something out of clay.

Ramesh Richard explains why he has called his sermon preparation steps 'Scripture sculpture' as follows:

"The Bible is what God has made. Sermons are what we make with what God has made".

Like creating a sculpture or carving wood, the craft of teaching the Bible means taking what God has given and using it to shape every aspect of our preparation and preaching.

2 Timothy 2:15 says: "Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a worker who does not need to be ashamed and who correctly handles the word of truth."

The word picture Paul uses is one of a workman cutting something straight, or cleanly. We do not know exactly what Paul had in mind, but it might have been a picture of a woodworker, carving and shaping the wood well. What is clear is that we are to be well equipped to understand, explain and apply the Scriptures. A good woodworker knows how best to use the grain or structure of the wood itself to create beautiful carvings. A good Bible-worker uses the shape and structure of the Scriptures to understand, apply and communicate it well.

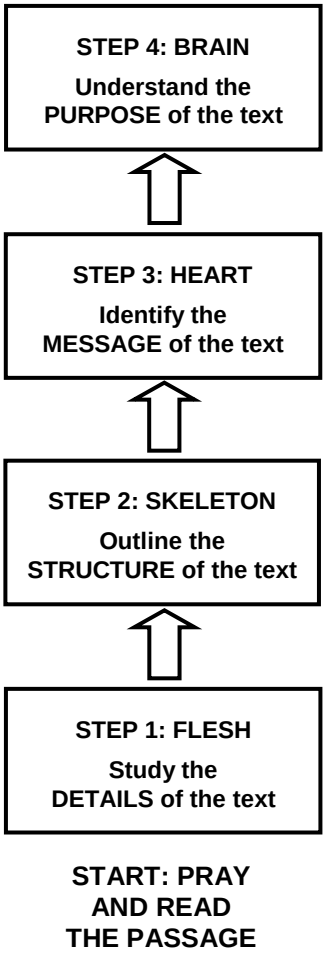
What is also clear is that preaching and praying belong together. In all our preparation we must obey Paul's command to "pray continually" (1 Thess. 5:17). A background of prayer applies to all the steps, the first four of which are illustrated below.

4.2 FOUR STEPS FOR ENCOUNTERING A PASSAGE OF THE BIBLE

4.2.1 Seeing the four steps in your mind's eye

The Scripture Sculpture process uses a very powerful image, that of living carving of a person with flesh and bones, a heart and a brain. This is appropriate because God's word is a living word that comes to us and speaks to us. Start at the bottom of the diagram, which makes it easier to imagine because the brain or mind of the passage is at the top or head.

FOUR STEPS FOR ENCOUNTERING A PASSAGE OF THE BIBLE IN OUTLINE



Imagine these steps as four steps in the creation of a carving that comes to life and walks off the pages of Scripture. These are four steps in our prayerful preparation to preach.

First, the more you study the ‘flesh’ or body of the text on the pages of the Bible, the more familiar the details become and the main findings emerge.

Second, as you continue to spend time in the text its structure appears: the outline or ‘skeleton’ takes shape and becomes clear.

Third, further study leads to you grasping the message or ‘heart’ of the passage, which in turn begins to grip you.

Fourth, and finally, you begin to see the ‘brain’ or the purpose behind the Bible passage.

4.2.2 Four steps for encountering a passage of the Bible explained

The table below gives the outcome of each main step, and also breaks that step down into manageable parts for you.

FOUR STEPS FOR ENCOUNTERING A PASSAGE OF THE BIBLE IN DETAIL

STEP 1: FLESH – Study the DETAILS of the text At the end of this step you will be familiar with the key components of the passage. You need to: a) Set the text in **context** b) See the **details** c) Seek the **meaning** d) Summarise the **findings**
STEP 2: SKELETON – Outline the STRUCTURE of the text At the end of this step you will be able to outline the structure of the passage and see how the author makes his point. You need to: a) Note the various **'bones'** in the passage b) Create an **outline**, having identified the 'big bones'
STEP 3: HEART – Identify the MESSAGE of the text At the end of this step you will be able to write out the author's main point in one or two sentences. You need to: a) State the **theme** of the passage b) Capture the **message** of the passage
STEP 4: BRAIN – Understand the PURPOSE of the text At the end of this step you will be able to explain the purpose of the passage and will begin to make connections for teaching it today. You need to: a) State the **purpose** of the passage b) Make **connections** for teaching it today

4.3 THE FOUR STEPS APPLIED TO 2 TIM 1:6-7

Before you go any further READ THE PASSAGE!

4.3.1 STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text

At the end of this step you will be familiar with the key components of the passage as you **set** the text in context, **see** the details, **seek** the meaning and **summarise** the findings.

a) Set the text in context

Keep the general information about 2 Timothy from Unit 3 in mind as you set 2 Tim 1:6-7 in the context of the book as a whole. In order to do that we can use the same three words that we learnt there: **story**, **situation** and **style**.

Story
When you receive a letter from someone you do not only look at one paragraph: you read the whole letter and come to understand its various parts. A passage can only be properly understood in the context and argument of the book as a whole. Trying to understand a passage of a book without knowing the book itself is like trying to get to know a member of a family without knowing their wider family and where they live.

We have seen where 2 Timothy fits in the story of the Bible as a whole. It is also important to note where a particular passage comes in **the story of the Bible book** it is a part of.

- Where does 2 Tim 1:6-7 come in the argument of the book? How might this help us to understand our verses? Tip: Look at what comes before and after.

Situation

- What do you notice about this passage in relation to what we have already noticed about the book of 2 Timothy – the people, problems and places?

Style
We need to think again about Paul's style of writing. Remember, 2 Timothy is a letter that explains and applies the truth of the gospel in a particular situation.

- What do you notice about 2 Tim 1:6-8 that shows that it is part of a letter?

b) See the details of the text

We have already begun to notice some of the details; we will now highlight the most important ones. To do this we will **look** for the important details, **mark** them on the passage, and then **list** them.

Look
As you read the passage, look out for the most important details:

1. **Repeated** and **related** words and phrases

2. Other **important**, **complicated** and **unusual** words and phrases

3. **Connections** and **links** between the words and phrases

Because "*all* Scripture is God breathed" (2 Tim 3:16), *all* of the details are important. But some stand out and are particularly important.

Because the letter is a form of *teaching* we are looking for the argument and how it is built. So, first, look for words and phrases that indicate the main themes and ideas. And, second, look for words that indicate: the reasoning (for..., therefore..., if...); contrasts (not..., but...); comparisons and illustrations (like...); and connections (and..., this..., which...).

- Have a look at 2 Tim 1:6-7. What important words, phrases and relationships do you see? At this point just look. We will highlight them and list them in a moment.

Mark
Marking or highlighting a text is a helpful way of visualising things: seeing with your eyes what you hear with your ears. It will improve your powers of observation and help you in your learning and your teaching.

Drawing and highlighting details on the passage is very useful when you "study the flesh of the text" – particularly as you examine it to "see the details". But it will also help you with Step 2 as you "note all the bones in the structure" and as you "outline the skeleton of the text".

This is not only a useful tool to use when you are working on your own, it is also helpful when working in a group, because everyone can see the details and make a contribution. In other words it encourages participation and learning.

The passage we are looking at – 2 Timothy 1:6-7 – is given below. This is how it might appear in a Bible but in a magnified form. Your Trainer will demonstrate how you can write on, underline, divide up the passage and draw on the text to help the important details to stand out. Be imaginative and creative and use different shapes and colours if you can.

If you do have colours to use here is a simple system to follow. Red, green and blue are the most common colours we tend to use. You can think of these in relation to the **green** of the grass, the **red** of the soil and the **blue** of the sky above as a way to remember. Use the colours as follows:

1. For **repeated** or **related** words and phrases use **green**
2. For other **important** or **unusual** words and phrases use **red**
3. For **connections** and **links** between the words and phrases use **blue**

You can then use **black** (or **white** chalk) for more general underlining, notes and structural divisions.

But remember, **be selective**. If you mark everything you have marked nothing!

Depending on the situation, you might like to photocopy the text of the Bible, or simply write out the passage in full on a piece of paper or board.

ENCOUNTERING 2 TIMOTHY 1:6-7 – THE PASSAGE

> 6 For this reason I remind you to fan into flame the gift of God, which is in you through the laying on of my hands. 7 For the Spirit God gave us does not make us timid, but gives us power, love and self-discipline. (NIV)

List
Once you have marked the passage, **list** the important words and phrases on one side of a page, as in the column ‘see the details’ in the table below.

c) Seek the meaning from the details

Ask and answer questions:

- What do these words and phrases mean today in your language?
- What did they mean in the context of the passage when it was written?
- What is their significance in the passage and book?
- Review your answers – are they simple, true and consistent in the context of the book, the group of books and the Bible?

Record your observations in the table below. Your Trainer will guide you.

See the details of the text List words, phrases, and relationships:	**Seek the meaning from the details** Explain words, phrases, and relationships:

d) Summarise your findings

Draw on all the above. What are the main things you have discovered, the most important ideas that you want to carry forward?

Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?

4.3.2 STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text

At the end of this step you will be able to sketch out the structure of the passage and see how Paul makes his point.

a) Note the various 'bones' in the passage

You are aiming to discover how Paul has structured his writing or flow of thought, so that you can understand the message it carries. The clues are in the details and you may have begun to notice the structure. While 2 Timothy 1:6-7 is short and will have a single theme, even a short section of a letter has a structure. That structure may be clearest in the links and logic, or in the arrangement of the themes or ideas.

Links
In Paul's writing the links and the logic are important parts of the structure.

- What important links contribute to the structure?

Themes
The way the ideas or themes are arranged also creates structure.

- Look at the main ideas from your study of the flesh of the text. How are they arranged in the passage?

b) Create an outline, having identified the 'big bones'

There are major parts of the structure and minor ones; big bones and small bones. What are the 'big bones' in the passage that give it shape and structure? How would you divide up the passage? Capture this by making a simple summary outline of the passage.

4.3.3 STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text

At the end of this step you will be able to write out Paul's main point in a sentence or two.

Remember, the Bible is 'God preaching' to his people. Therefore a biblical message is more than just information; it tells us something important and practical about that information.

A simple way of identifying the message of a passage is this: note the author's theme and note what he says about that theme.

a) State the theme of the passage

Take time and care to reflect on and pray over your discoveries so far and capture the theme as simply and as clearly as you can by answering the question below.

- What is the main thing Paul is talking about?

b) Capture the message of the passage

Think about this theme and answer the question, what is the author saying about this theme in this text? Try and do this simply and clearly, without using technical words, and ideally in a way even a child could understand it.

Remember, you are aiming to discover the original meaning of a text. To help with this try completing a sentence that begins with words such as: "Paul tells Timothy that...", or, "What Paul wants Timothy to know is...".

- Complete one of those sentences for our passage:

  "Paul tells Timothy that…

4.3.4 STEP 4: BRAIN – understand the PURPOSE of the text...

At the end of this step you will be able to explain the purpose of the passage and will have made some connections so that you can teach it today.

a) State the purpose of the passage

Keeping in mind the context of the passage you need to answer the question: Why is Paul making this point?

- Answer that question for our passage:

b) Make connections for teaching today

The aim of the first four steps of Scripture Sculpture is to discover the original meaning of the passage. However, the real aim of encountering a passage of Scripture is to apply it to our lives and ministries and to experience its transforming power. We want to discover the significance of the passage for us today. We must keep in mind not only where the passage belongs in its original context, but also where it belongs in our hearts and lives, in our congregations and communities.

The message statement, **what** is being said, is important as we make connections today. The purpose statement, **why** it is being said is also important.

Think about **what** you and your people need to hear from this Bible passage and **why** they need to hear it.

- Capture that idea in the form of a statement or a question that makes some connections with your situation and your congregation's situation today.

4.4 PULLING IT ALL TOGETHER

The two tables below pull together our discoveries in the first four steps of the Scripture Sculpture process. They do this in a format that we will use throughout the BUILD curriculum when encountering a passage of the Bible.

4.4.1 Pulling it all together: Step 1 of the Scripture Sculpture process

STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text

a) Set the passage in context. How does the passage relate to the book as a whole?

Story: Verses 3-5 emphasise the reality of Timothy's faith.

Verse 6 begins with the words, "For this reason..." Paul's confidence in Timothy's faith means he has a basis for his appeal for Timothy to "fan into flame the gift of God..."

Verse 8 then tells Timothy: "So do not be ashamed of the testimony about our Lord..." Verses 6 and 7 must give a reason for Timothy not to be ashamed and to have confidence.

Situation: The passage communicates the close, personal nature of Paul and Timothy's relationship.

Style: A section a letter, which builds a clear argument; it explains and applies the gospel.

b) See the details of the text	**c) Seek the meaning from the details**
List words, phrases, and relationships:	Explain words, phrases, and relationships:
"For this reason..."	Links back – 'based on what I have said…'
"remind" (links with "remember", "recalling" and "reminded" in the previous verses)	Paul has been remembering things; Timothy needs to remember something important too.
"fan into flame" (the main thing Paul calls Timothy to do)	Timothy must renew his passion and reignite and rekindle the gifts that he has
"the gift of God", "God gave" and "gives" (repeated ideas)	Paul encourages Timothy that God has given him all he needs for this ministry
"laying on of hands" (complex, needs explaining)	1 Tim 4:14 ties the gifts to the public recognition of Timothy's ministry
"For" (introduces an explanation)	Paul will explain more about this gift
"Spirit"	God's Holy Spirit, his empowering presence
"timid" and "power" (important and contrasting words)	Personal weakness contrasted with the Spirit's strength
"does not" and "but" (contrast)	Underlines the contrast
"power, love and self-discipline" (important phrase)	The Spirit has these qualities and brings them to Timothy. They are a perfect blend – each quality needs the other two.

d) Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?

Paul is convinced that Timothy's faith in Christ is genuine.

Because of this confidence Paul reminds Timothy to do something important. Timothy must renew his confidence in God and his gifts.

The greatest gift of all is that of God's Holy Spirit with us. He is powerful, loving and self-disciplined.

4.4.2 Pulling it all together: Steps 2 – 4 of the Scripture Sculpture process

STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text

a) Note all the bones in the structure. What elements highlight the structure?

Links. “For this reason” links the passage to the content of the previous one: the confidence Timothy can have in the reality of his own God-given faith.

And the word “for” (v. 7) links with verses 6 and 7. Timothy is to obey the command of v 6 not only because of the confidence he can have in his own faith (which v. 5 speaks of), but also because of the content of verse 7: Timothy is to stir up and exercise his gifts because of the nature and character of God’s Holy Spirit who has been given to him.

There are also smaller ‘bones’ that add to the structure. The words “which” and “through”, as well as “does not” and “but”, which create a contrast.

Themes. Verse 6 begins with an introduction, which is contained in the words “for this reason”. Those words look back to the confidence Paul has in Timothy’s “sincere” faith.

The verse continues with a command for Timothy to obey: “fan into flame the gift of God”. He is to exercise his gifts for gospel ministry with confidence.

Verse 6 then adds to that by explaining how that gift became a recognised part of Timothy’s life and ministry – this also emphasises confidence because it was a public event that had witnesses (1 Tim 4:14).

Verse 7 gives another reason for Timothy to use his gifts with confidence rather than fear.

b) Decide on the ‘big bones’ and make an outline of the structure. What are the most important parts of the structure? Can you describe the main sections?

1. The introduction to confidence in God and his gifts: Timothy can be confident in his faith (v. 6a) because Paul has already assured him it is “sincere” (v. 5).

2. The command to renew confidence in God and his gifts: Timothy can be confident that he has the God-given gifts for ministry, therefore he must rekindle them (v. 6b).

3. The reason to renew confidence in God and his gifts: God’s Spirit is committed and resilient, and we have the presence of this confidence building Spirit in our lives (v. 7).

STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text

a) State the theme of the passage. What is the author’s main point?

The theme is, Renewing confidence in God and his gifts for ministry.

b) State the message of the passage. What is the author saying about his theme?

Paul tells Timothy to renew his confidence in God and his gifts for ministry.

STEP 4: BRAIN – first, understand the PURPOSE of the text...

a) State the purpose of the passage. Why is the author making this point?

Paul tells Timothy to renew his confidence in God and his gifts because he is facing an urgent and demanding task, one that he cannot overcome with his own abilities and strength.

b) Make connections for teaching today. What is the relevance of this for us?

In the face of all the daily demands and difficulties we face, how can we renew our confidence in God and his gifts for ministry?

4.5 CONCLUSION: RESPONDING TO THE MESSAGE OF 2 TIMOTHY 1:6-7

We will learn more about how to preach and teach from Bible passages in Unit 13. That unit will use 2 Tim 1:6-7 as an example. But it is important for us to respond to the passages we will encounter before then. Here are three simple exercises to do in response to God's word to us in 2 Tim 1:6-7:

1. Describe how the message you discovered in the passage spoke to you personally: What did you learn or need to be reminded of?

2. Share how the purpose of the passage helped you to apply God's word to your life: What change will this passage make to your thinking and living?

3. State and explain the message you will share with others using your own words: What is the main thing you want people to understand?